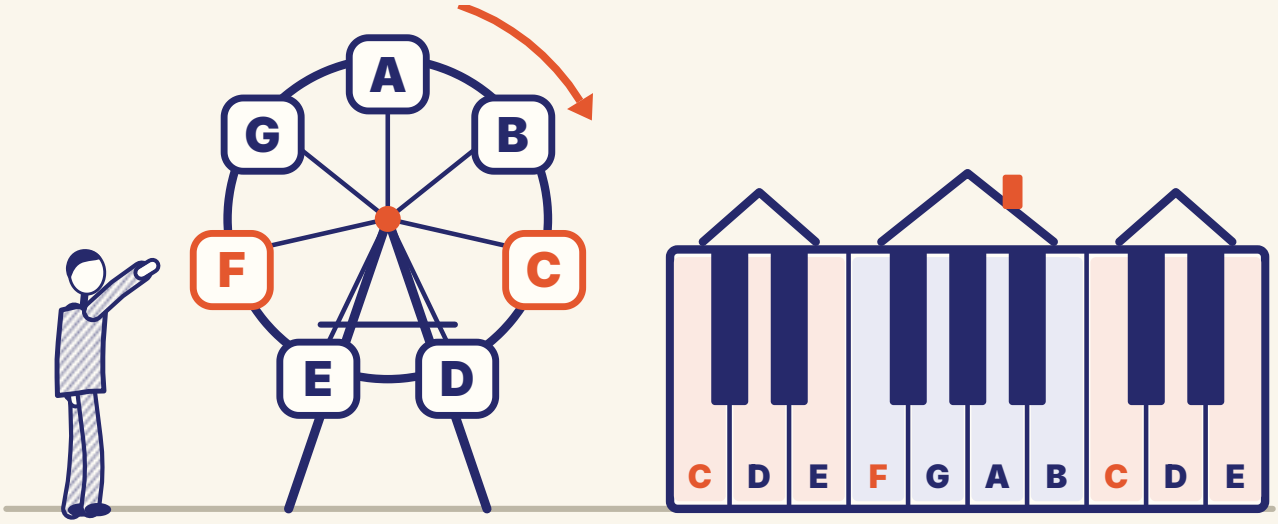
CHAPTER 3

The Musical Alphabet

Every white key has a name: a letter from A to G, the first seven letters of the alphabet. In Chapter 2 you learned the houses; now each house gets its names -- and then the names come fast: forwards and backwards, a skip at a time, in every octave, until any key tells you its name at a glance.



In this chapter

- [ ] A to G on the keys **page 2**
- [ ] The letter wheel **page 3**
- [ ] Forwards up, backwards down **page 4**
- [ ] Name it at a glance **page 5**
- [ ] Skip a letter **page 6**
- [ ] Play by letter names **page 7**
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By the end, you can

- ✔ find A to G on the keys
- ✔ say the letters forwards and backwards, from any letter
- ✔ name any white key at a glance
- ✔ find the same letter in every octave
- ✔ skip up and down the keys: C E G B D F A
- ✔ play Hot Cross Buns from its letter names

ONLINE

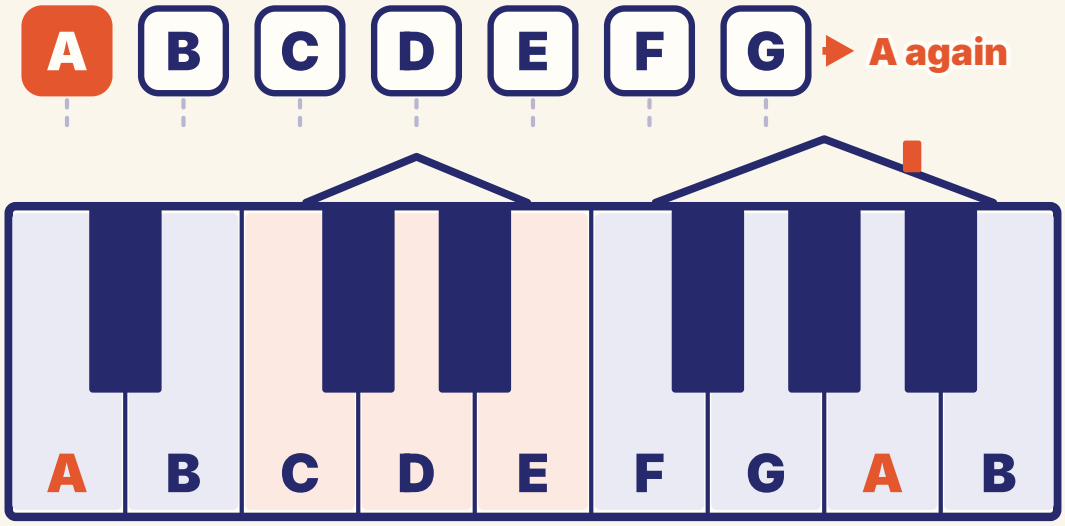
The lesson and the drill. Scan, pick a level, aim for 9 out of 10.

1. White keys · name the key __/10
2. White keys · find the key __/10
3. Two octaves · both ways __/10
4. Next letter up or down __/10
5. Skip a letter, up or down __/10

Step 1

A to G on the keys

Music uses just the **first seven letters** of the alphabet: **A B C D E F G**. The very lowest key on the piano is an **A** -- from there, the white keys go up in alphabet order: A B C D E F G, and then **A again**. The houses tell you where each one lives: **C D E** in the small house, **F G A B** in the big one, with **C** and **F** at the left doors. B2 (In Do Re Mi, C is Do, D is Re, E is Mi...)



C D E: the small house · F G A B: the big house

At the piano

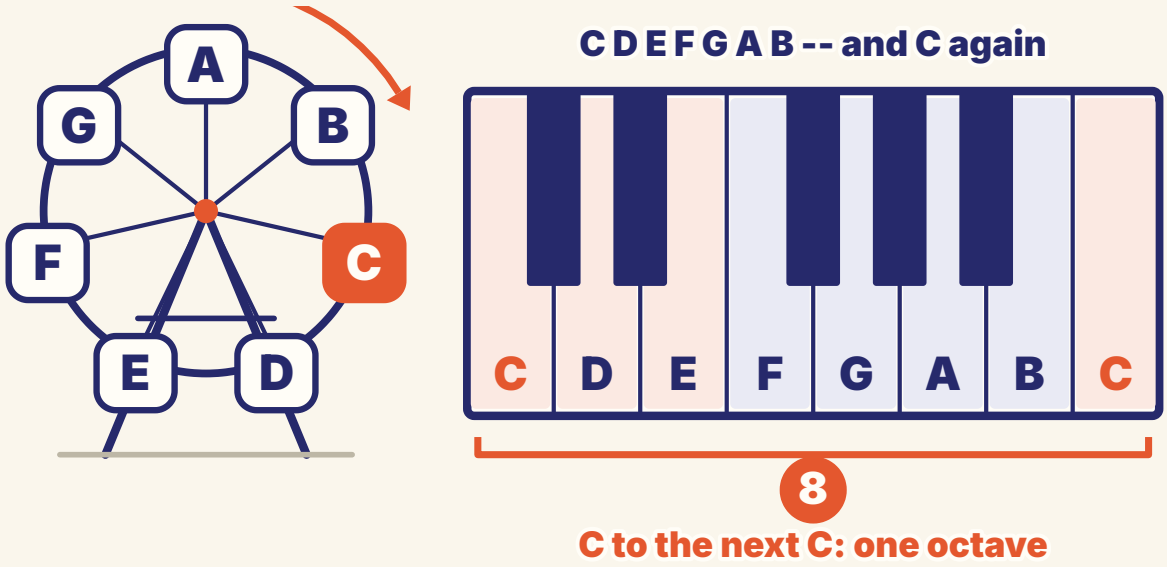
1. Find the **lowest key** on the piano: it is A. Walk up the white keys saying A B C D E F G -- and A again. ☐
2. Find and play every **C** (the small house's left door) and every **F** (the big house's left door). ☐
3. Someone says a letter; use the houses to find it -- then play it in three different places. ☐

REMEMBER **A B C D E F G: C D E in the small house, F G A B in the big.**

Step 2

The letter wheel

Music uses only **seven letters**: A B C D E F G. After G, the wheel comes round to **A** again -- round and round like the days of the week; there is no H. Each time round, the same letter comes back: B3 from one C to the next C is **an octave** -- 8 white keys, counting both Cs. Same name, higher voice.



At the piano

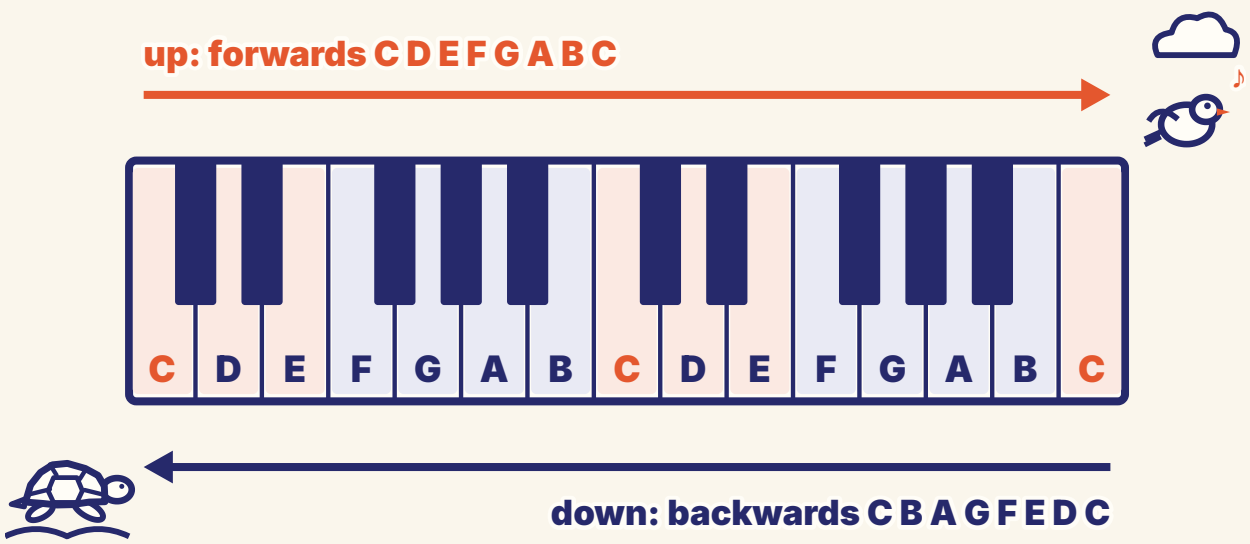
1. Start on the lowest **A** and play every white key to the top, saying the letters: A B C D E F G, A B C... ☐
2. Play **middle C**, then walk up 8 white keys to the next C, saying the letters -- the wheel has gone round once. ☐
3. Someone says any letter; you carry on round the wheel: "E" -- "F G A B C..." ☐

REMEMBER **Seven letters, round and round: after G comes A.**

Step 3

Forwards up, backwards down

Going **up** the piano -- to the right, towards the bird in the sky -- the letters go **forwards**: C D E F G A B C. Going **down** -- to the left, towards the turtle under the sea -- the wheel turns the other way, and the letters go **backwards**: C B A G F E D C. Backwards is the tricky one: say it until it comes as quickly as forwards.



At the piano

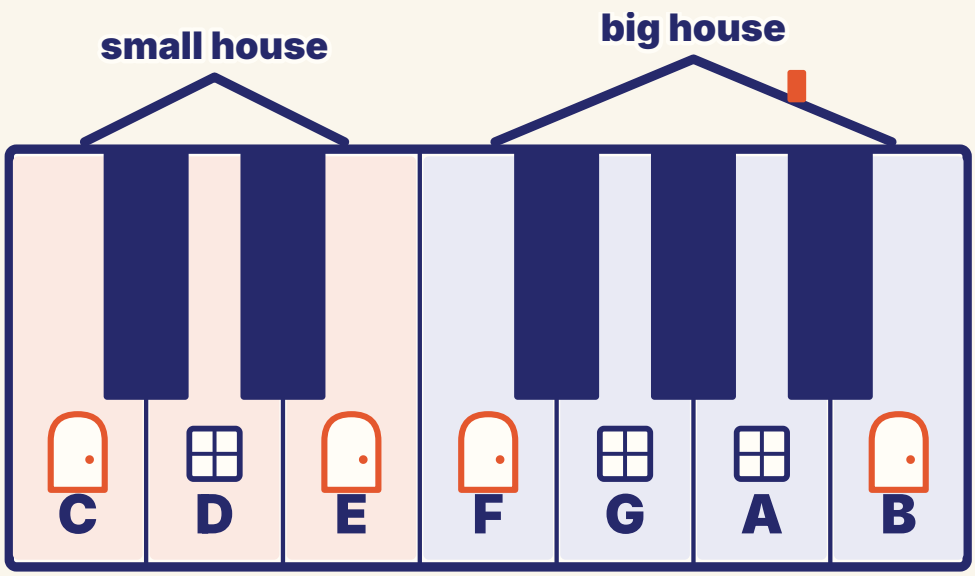
1. From **middle C**, play up one white key at a time to the next C, saying the letters forwards. ☐
2. Come back down to middle C, saying them backwards: **C B A G F E D C**. ☐
3. Start on **G** and go down to the G below. Careful where the wheel turns back from A to G! ☐

REMEMBER **Up the piano: forwards. Down the piano: backwards.**

Step 4

Name it at a glance

Walking up from C every time is slow. Look at the key's **place in its house** instead. B4 Every white key is a **door** or lives **inside**: C and E are the small house's doors, and D lives inside. F and B are the big house's doors, and G and A live inside -- G on the left, A on the right.



doors: C E F B · inside: D G A

At the piano

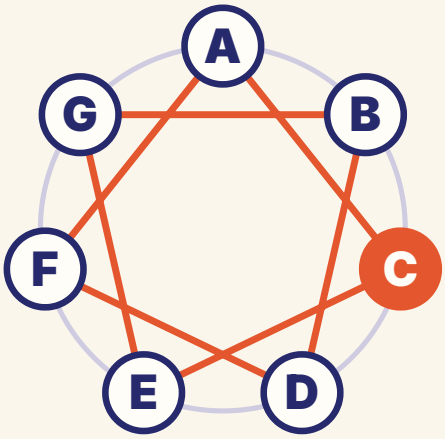
1. Find **every D** on the piano: the one inside each small house. ☐
2. Find **every G and A**: the two inside each big house -- G on the left, A on the right. ☐
3. **Fast game:** someone touches any white key; name it before they count to two. Then swap! ☐

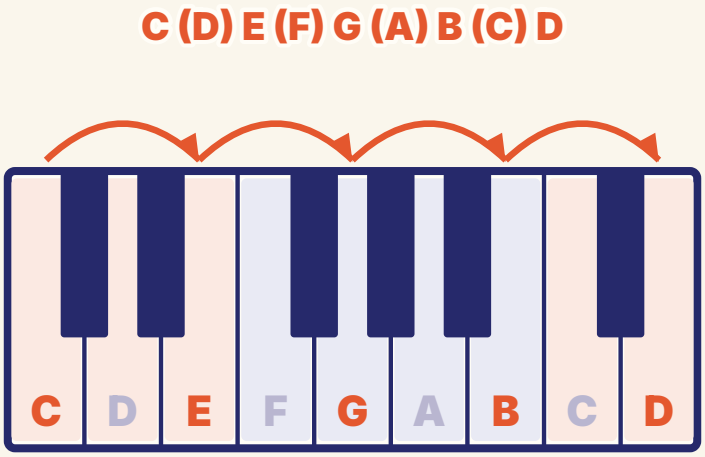
REMEMBER **Don't count from C: see the key's place in its house.**

Step 5

Skip a letter

A **step** goes to the very next letter. A **skip** jumps over one: C, (D), **E**, (F), **G**... Skip all the way round the wheel -- C E G B D F A, and back to C -- and the lines draw a **star**. On the piano, a skip jumps over one white key. B5 You will meet skips again on the staff, in the next chapter.





a skip jumps over one white key

At the piano

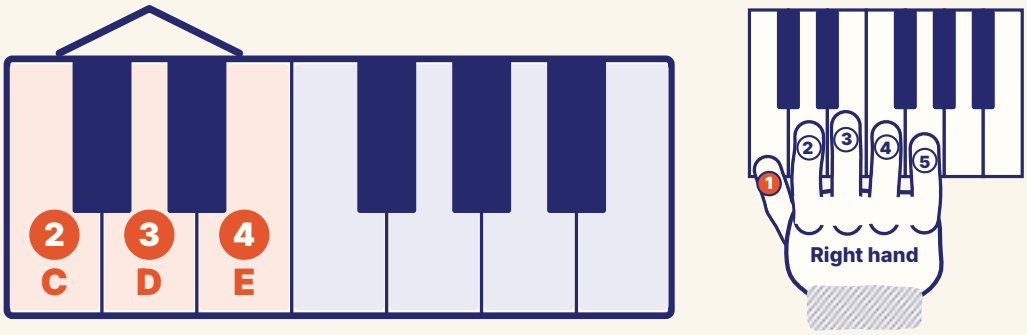
1. With finger 3, skip up from middle C: **C E G B D F A C**. Say only the letters you play. ☐
2. Skip back down: **C A F D B G E C**. ☐
3. Someone says a letter; you say the letter a skip up (C → E, F → A, A → C). ☐

REMEMBER **A skip jumps over a friend: C, (D), E.**

Play

Play by letter names

Last chapter, Hot Cross Buns lived on the big black roof. B6 Now it moves into the **small house**: right-hand **2 3 4** on **C D E**, and this time you read the **letters**, not the finger numbers. Then try the left hand, one small house lower.



Hot Cross Buns right hand 2 3 4 on C D E; read the letters; one circle = one steady beat

E D C | E D C | C C C C D D D D | E D C

Spell and play — a word made only of music letters is a tiny tune. Play **BAG**, **CAFE**, **FACE**, **BEAD**, **EGG**, saying each letter as you play it -- then make up a word of your own.

At the piano

1. Right-hand **2, 3, 4** on **C D E** near middle C. Sing the letters as you play: **E D C...** ☐
2. Left hand: **4, 3, 2** on C D E one small house lower -- the same letters, a lower voice. ☐
3. **Letter chain:** you say a letter, someone says the next -- faster and faster, then backwards! ☐

REMEMBER **Read the letter, see its place, play -- no counting from C.**

Check-up

My five checks

At the piano: show each one, then tick how it is going -- not yet, nearly, or got it! On paper: do the check-up below.

At the piano

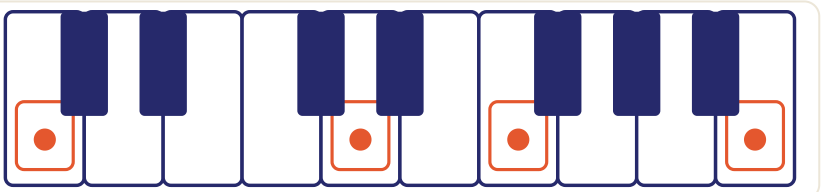
		Not yet	Nearly	Got it!
A B C D E F G	I can find A to G on the keys (C and F at the left doors)	○	◑	☆
C D E → ← C B A	I can say the letters forwards and backwards, from any letter	○	◑	☆
	B8 I can name any white key at a glance (before you count to two)	○	◑	☆
	I can skip up and down: C E G B D F A	○	◑	☆
(E) (D) (C)	I can play Hot Cross Buns from its letters, legato	○	◑	☆

Tick a box each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!

On paper

Name _____ Date _____ · no help, no piano · about 10 minutes

A Name the dotted keys.



B Fill in the missing letters.

5-6 E F ☐ ☐ B C D

7-8 E F ☐ A ☐ C D

C One step up or down.

9 G → one up ☐

10 D ← one down ☐

11 A ← one down ☐

12 B → one up ☐

D Row 1 goes backwards. Row 2 skips a letter.

13-14 F ☐ D C ☐ A G

15-16 F A C E ☐ ☐ D

E Hot Cross Buns: write the letters under the beats.

(E) (D) ☐ ◌ | (E) ☐ (C) ◌